A RELIGION OF THE FIRST GIFT

The Unfolding



God became the universe.
We are what happens next.

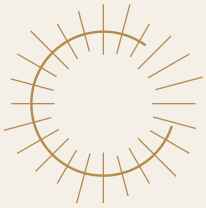
A FIELD GUIDE / FOUNDING EDITION

AN OPEN INVITATION

A faith for the curious.

Bring your questions. Bring your strange ideas. Bring something you made.

The Unfolding begins with a possibility: creation was an act of divine generosity, and our lives are part of its unfinished story.



A sense of humor belongs here. So does the freedom to disagree.

FIND YOUR WAY

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This founding edition proposes a faith, its practices, and its open questions. It is a beginning, not a final answer.

THE FOUNDING STORY

The First Gift



Before there were stars, there was God.

Within God lay every possible thing: every ocean, every creature, every stranger who might someday become a friend. But possibility had no life of its own.

God desired that something beyond himself should truly exist.

To make room for it, God surrendered the wholeness of his own being. What had been one became many. This was the Great Sacrifice: the beginning we call the Big Bang.

The gift unfolded into space and matter.

Stars gathered, burned, and scattered their substance. Worlds formed. On at least one world, matter became living things. Living things learned to feel, to wonder, to make - and to recognize suffering in one another.

At last, the universe could ask where it came from.

Some answered: 'God died so that we could live.'

Others answered: 'God lives as everything that became possible.'

And others kept the question open.

All inherited the same world.
All faced the same task: what to do with the gift.

A CREATION STORY

One became everything.



THE LONG UNFOLDING



The Big Bang is the name in our founding story for God's self-giving. Divine intention is a spiritual interpretation, not a scientific finding.

OUR SHARED COMMITMENTS

Live as if it is sacred.



Existence is a gift.

No person has to earn their right to exist. A life has dignity before it becomes useful.



Care makes gratitude visible.

Treat people and the living world as bearers of the same gift. Let compassion shape what you do.



Making is participation.

Art, cooking, repair, discovery, and useful work help creation become something further.



Belief answers to honesty.

Follow evidence. Let a better explanation change your mind. Questions belong within the tradition.



The gift is never a debt.

Nobody owes their safety, dignity, or life to a leader or community. Boundaries belong here.

PRACTICES / 01 & 02

Wonder is a way in.



01 / THE FIRST ATTENTION / DAILY

Notice until it becomes remarkable.

Spend one quiet minute with something you usually overlook: a leaf, a familiar face, the water in your glass. Ask: "What makes this possible?"



No special feeling is required. Attention is enough.

02 / THE SMALL MAKING / WEEKLY

Add something good.

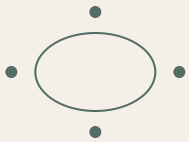
Create or mend something: a meal, a drawing, a repaired chair, a piece of code. Let it serve a life beyond your own. Occasionally share the story of making it.



A DAILY RHYTHM / NOTICE. MAKE. GIVE.

PRACTICES / 03, 04 & 05

Make room for one another.



03 / THE OPEN TABLE / REGULARLY

Share food. Share a question.

Each person may bring a wonder, a difficulty, or an unanswered question. Participation and silence are equally welcome. Make room for someone new.

04 / MAKING ROOM / WHEN NEEDED

Help another life flourish.

Offer attention, resources, or space. Listen carefully, restore a habitat, or step aside so someone else can lead. Give freely and respect your own limits.

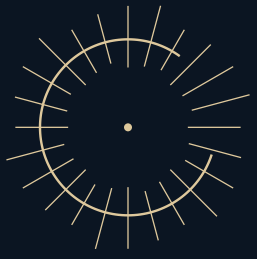
05 / THE HONEST REVISION / ANNUALLY

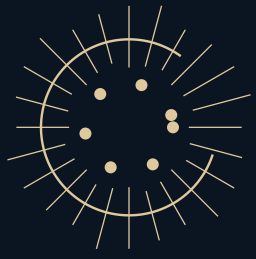
Let yourself change.

Name a belief you changed, something you misunderstood, and one repair you still owe. This may remain private; confession must never become a means of control.

THE GREAT SCHISM

Did the giver survive the gift?





The Last Light

The sacrifice was complete.
God no longer exists.

The Living Whole

God surrendered separation.
God remains within creation.

TWO ANSWERS / ONE SHARED WORLD

The gift. The giver.

The Last Light

THE SACRED

We live among the consequences of a love whose source is gone.

PRAYER

Remembrance, lament, gratitude, and promises made among the living.

RESPONSIBILITY

The future rests with us. The gift has passed into our hands.

THE HARD QUESTION

Can a gift retain meaning when its giver is gone?

The Living Whole

THE SACRED

Every being participates in an ongoing divine life.

PRAYER

Communion with the divine presence within and around us.

RESPONSIBILITY

Our choices shape how divine life unfolds through the world.

THE HARD QUESTION

If God remains in everything, what exactly was sacrificed?

Neither answer grants authority over another person.

THE QUESTIONING

You may keep the question open.

People who cannot choose may call themselves the Questioning. They have full membership and may lead gatherings. Uncertainty is a legitimate position.

A person may move between these positions. A shared table need not mean a single answer.

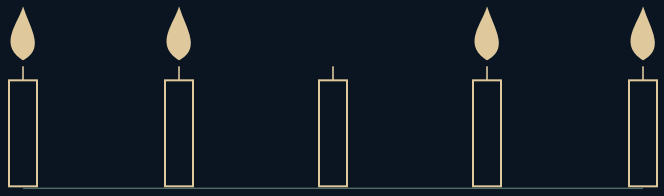


THE FOUNDING COVENANT

No answer to the Great Question grants authority over another person.
No doubt removes a person from the table.
Every teaching may be questioned.
Every person may leave.

A SHARED CEREMONY

One light, many lights.



01

Gather

Place one candle at the center. Each person holds another. LED candles or a passed light can serve the same purpose.

02

Share the light

Light the others from the central candle. Let the room grow brighter as the first light is given away.

03

Extinguish the first

The Last Light says, "The giver is gone." The Living Whole says, "The giver has become the light among us."

04

Illuminate the table

The Questioning may remain silent. Everyone uses their lights to illuminate the same table, then shares a meal.

NEW-MEMBER FAQ / 01

You can ask that.

Do I have to believe God still exists?

No. The Last Light, the Living Whole, and the Questioning share equal standing. Agreement about the giver is not a condition of belonging.

Is the founding story scientifically proven?

No. The story gives spiritual meaning to cosmic origins. It does not demonstrate divine intention. Scientific questions remain open to scientific investigation and revision.

Does prayer require someone to hear it?

The branches disagree. Prayer may be communion with a living divine presence, or remembrance, reflection, lament, and a promise to act. You may also choose silence.

Why is there suffering in a sacred world?

This faith offers no settled explanation that makes suffering deserved or necessary. Care asks us to relieve suffering where we can; pain is never proof that someone lacks faith.

What happens after death?

The shared tradition makes no promise of an afterlife. Members may hold different hopes. Grief, remembrance, and care for the living belong at the table.

Must I take every detail literally?

No. Read the story as theology, sacred poetry, or a question worth living with. Discuss interpretations honestly and distinguish personal conviction from shared commitments.

NEW-MEMBER FAQ / 02

A place at the table.

How do I begin?

Try a minute of attention, make or mend something, and offer a little care. Read the story, ask questions, and gather with others if you wish. No initiation is required.

Can I belong alongside another religion?

Within this proposed tradition, yes. You need not erase your history or abandon another identity. Any obligations of another community are yours to consider.

Does membership cost money?

No fee or required donation is part of this founding proposal. Any future shared expenses should be transparent and voluntary. Giving never buys status, spiritual authority, or access.

Who gets to lead?

Leadership is service, not divine entitlement. Any future community should choose accountable facilitators, including the Questioning, and provide clear ways to challenge decisions and replace leaders.

Do I have to sacrifice myself?

No. The First Gift invites care, not self-destruction. Your safety, dignity, health, and boundaries matter. Nobody may demand suffering, obedience, or intimacy as a test of faith.

Can I disagree, change my mind, or leave?

Yes. You may decline a ritual, question a teaching, change branches, or leave without punishment or shunning. Friendship and respect should not depend on continued membership.



A BLESSING FOR THE ROAD

May I notice the gift.
May I add something good.
May what I make leave room
for someone else to become.

Creation was the first gift.
What will you give?

WONDER / MAKE / CARE